



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 07

Proteins I: Poultry & Meat

Butchery basics, the big roasting and braising methods, and judging meat by temperature.

Weeks 12-13 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

- 1 Break down a whole chicken into eight pieces.
- 2 Roast, sear, and braise meat and poultry to target temperatures.
- 3 Understand cuts: which are for fast heat vs. low-and-slow.
- 4 Rest meat and build a pan sauce or jus.

LESSON 7.1

Meat Science and Buying

Objective: Understand muscle, fat, and collagen so you can match cut to method.

Key points

- Tough, hard-working cuts (chuck, shank) want low-and-slow moist heat.
- Tender cuts (loin, rib) want fast, dry, high heat.
- Marbling = intramuscular fat = flavor and juiciness.
- Let meat temper toward room temp before cooking for even doneness.

Watch out for

- Grilling a tough braising cut, leaving it chewy.
- Slow-braising a tender steak cut, drying it out.
- Cooking ice-cold meat, so the outside overcooks before the center warms.

LESSON 7.2

Breaking Down a Whole Chicken

Objective: Fabricate a whole chicken into eight pieces and save the carcass.

Key points

- The eight-piece cut: 2 drumsticks, 2 thighs, 2 wings, 2 breasts.
- Cut through joints, not bone - find the gap and the knife glides.
- Keep the carcass and trim for stock (Module 4).
- A sharp boning or chef's knife and deliberate cuts do the job.

Technique

1

Legs

Cut the skin, bend the leg back to pop the hip, and cut through.

2

Split

Separate drumstick from thigh at the knee joint.

3

Wings

Remove each wing at the shoulder joint.

4

Breasts

Cut along the keel bone to free each breast from the carcass.

LESSON 7.3

Roasting and Searing

Objective: Roast poultry and sear steaks to a target temperature.

Key points

- Dry the skin and season well for crisp roast chicken; breast to 165 deg F.
- Sear in a preheated pan and do not move the meat until it crusts.
- Reverse sear thick steaks: gentle oven, then a hard finishing sear.
- Cook to temperature, then rest before slicing.

Technique

- 1 Dry and season**
Pat dry, salt ahead, and let the surface dry.
- 2 Roast or sear**
High oven for poultry; preheated pan for steaks.
- 3 Check temp**
Pull a few degrees early for carryover.
- 4 Rest**
Rest before carving or slicing to keep juices in.

LESSON 7.4

Braising Tough Cuts

Objective: Turn a cheap, tough cut into something tender and rich.

Key points

- Sear hard first - that browning is most of the flavor.
- Add liquid only partway up the meat; full submersion boils, not braises.
- Keep a bare simmer (a low oven gives steady, even heat).
- Reduce the strained braising liquid into the sauce.

Technique

- 1 Sear**
Brown the meat deeply on all sides; remove.
- 2 Build**
Soften aromatics, deglaze, return the meat with partial liquid.
- 3 Braise**
Cover and cook low until fork-tender.
- 4 Finish**
Skim, strain, and reduce the liquid to a sauce.

Practice & homework

1

Break down a whole chicken; save the carcass for stock (Module 4).

2

Roast a chicken to 165 deg F in the breast and rest it; evaluate juiciness.

3

Braise a tough cut until fork-tender; reduce the braising liquid into sauce.

Watch & learn (free)



Jacques Pepin - Classic Roast Chicken (KQED)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sFtpo1nxX_k



J. Kenji Lopez-Alt (food science & technique)

<https://www.youtube.com/@JKenjiLopezAlt>



Brian Lagerstrom (ex-restaurant pro, approachable)

<https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom>



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Next up - Module 08: Proteins II: Fish & Seafood

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM